this, this time too, in place after place, they lost their election deposits. This is the biggest reason for the love the country is showing to the BJP today in polls.'[35] He was referring to the fact that thirty-one of the BJP's forty-one seats in the November 2020 by-polls came at the expense of the Congress.[36]

## The BJP Model of Economics: Low Inflation at Centre and in States (2014-19)

Depending on who you speak to, there are four broad views on Narendra Modi's economics. His detractors, BJP MP Swapan Dasgupta points out, have portrayed him as a 'man who is a master of expediency and who, at the same time, lacks any coherent political ideology beyond Nation First. This has also been a charge against the BJP.' The BJP and the Modi government, in this view, largely 'shied away' from the articulation of an economic philosophy,[37] or perhaps they never had an economic ideology after all, the economy being subservient to a cultural agenda.

The second view is that Modi took a sharp left turn in his first term. As the India Today Group's editorial director, Raj Chengappa, summarised in his post-Budget 2020 analysis, 'In his first term, saddled with back-to-back droughts that caused untold distress to farmers, and charged with being a "suit-boot Sarkar" by the Opposition, Modi took a sharp turn to the left and projected himself as a messiah of the poor, the downtrodden and farmers. He adopted a form of Swadeshi Socialism in his first term that is best remembered for the slew of development schemes that provided toilets, houses for the poor, cooking gas at subsidised prices and promised that highways and rural roads would be built at a rapid pace.'[38]

The third view is the governmental one: that the economic slowdown was cyclical, caused by external forces, and that a lot of economic activity was happening outside of formal numbers—for instance, with Mudra loans for small businesses—and that eventually India would right itself. In this view, the government did introduce reforms like Goods and Services Tax (GST) and the